School of Computing & Mathematical Sciences
MSc Project Guidance 2025-26

PG programmes require that each student undertakes an individual project, under the supervision of a staff member, which represents one third of the student's effort for the PG award (60 credits[1]). The project mark is determined by assessment of a project proposal (20%) and a project report including relevant documentation/appendices (80%). Passing the project is a requirement to get the MSc award. Therefore, students who fail to pass the project twice can only be awarded an Exit award, e.g. a Postgraduate Diploma which is awarded when a student has passed all taught modules. Students are responsible for familiarising themselves with the project module guidance/briefings, the pass criteria and the submission requirements before undertaking any assessments or reassessments.

There is no single "ideal" structure for an PG project report. These **MSc Project Guidance** notes and the slides on Moodle offer a general framework, which students across different PG programmes should adapt to fit their specific projects. The PG projects are supervised to help guide students toward the most suitable methodology and provide support, including advice on writing the final report. Students are expected to receive feedback on their work and assignments (proposal; report) directly from their supervisor and maintain contact with their supervisors throughout the duration of the module.

A proposal or report submitted for marking should have a cover/title page with the following information: Title of Project; Title of your Programme of Study; Your name; School of Computing and Mathematical Sciences, Birkbeck, University of London ; Word count.

The word limit for MSc project proposals is 3,000 words, with an additional allowance of up to 20 percent. The maximum length for the final report is 10,000 words, also with a permissible 20 percent extension. References and Appendices are excluded from the word count. Exceeding these limits will incur penalties as outlined below.

1. Aims of the Project

The main aims of the PG project are to offer students the opportunity to:

- develop a systematic understanding and critical awareness of an agreed problem relevant to the PG programme as described in a project proposal document;

[1] According to The Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education, one UK credit represents 10 hours of study.

- design, plan and execute a major piece of research, including programming work, appropriate to the PG programme of study;
- critically present existing approaches in the problem area, place their own approach in the wider area and evaluate their contribution;
- gain experience in communicating complex ideas/concepts and approaches/methods to others by writing a comprehensive, self-contained report.

2. Selecting a Project, Arranging Supervision and Submitting a Project Proposal

Students are expected to come up with their own ideas for projects, prepare a **Student Project Kernel** and find a supervisor. Alternatively, they can choose one of the **Staff Project Kernels** that describe project ideas proposed by staff. Further information is available on the PG project module on Moodle. Although the kernel is not marked, submitting it is a strong requirement for continuing with the project, and submitting later a proposal and a report.

A student intending to submit a project report in a particular year must submit first a project kernel and a project proposal agreed with their supervisor. Without a valid project kernel and project proposal, your project report will not be marked. The project proposal is an important part of the project module - it has a 20% weight, and the expected length is 2000-3000 words. Since the project counts 60 credits, the proposal alone is almost equivalent to a 15-credit PG module. The proposal should meet the following criteria:

- It identifies the aims and objectives of the project.
- It describes the problem that the project will address and its relevance to the PG programme followed.
- It presents background research on the problem and possible solutions in the form of a critical analysis of the literature.
- It identifies and justifies an appropriate approach/methodology which will be followed during the project.
- It includes a project plan which shows how the project objectives can be met within the required timescale.

The proposal must be submitted using the Moodle Virtual Learning Environment (VLE). **The proposal will go through the Turnitin detection service and receive a "plagiarism score" and an "AI writing detection score".** An independent marker and the supervisor verify the Turnitin scores, and they mark and moderate the submission respectively. Comments are provided through Moodle's Turnitin Feedback Studio, and students are expected to take these into consideration when developing their project. In addition, students should seek feedback on their work and assignments (proposal and report) directly from their supervisor and maintain regular contact with them throughout the module.

3. Proposal and Report Assessment Criteria and Marking

To **pass** a project the markers assess whether the project proposal and project report meet the following criteria. They also assess any other aspect of special relevance for the project. Here is a summary of the criteria. **For a detailed description of the PG Project Proposal and PG Project Report Marking Criteria per grade category, please refer to the PG project module on Moodle.**

Project Proposal:

- *Background research* (35%): potential approaches from the literature are reviewed and evaluated.
- *Presentation of the problem* (15%)*:* the proposal specifies a suitable problem and discusses its requirements.
- *Plan for developing the solution* (30%): a suitable development/research method/theory is chosen and the various methods/models that will be adopted are presented. The project is broken down into manageable chunks and a timeplan is produced.
- *Presentation of the proposal* (20%): this is coherent in style and structure with appropriate referencing. Any work exceeding the specified word limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion, i.e. the maximum mark one could take for Presentation is 10 out of 20 marks.

Project Report:

- *Specification and design* (20%): the specification of the planned project, the design of the system/research, software/models/tools, data analysis/AI/machine-learning pipeline is laid out and justified.
- *Implementation or execution of research* (30%): the key stages of the implementation or research are explained. The implementation or investigation is sound and appropriate to the problem and its requirements.
- *Testing and evaluation, results, analysis, and reflection* (30%): the report uses appropriate testing and evaluation methods, grounded on relevant literature, and attempts to provide a clear and justified reflection upon the contribution and its limitations. It discusses how the investigation, system, software, or data analysis/AI/machine-learning approach meets the specified requirements.
- *Presentation and completeness of the report* (20%): the report is coherent in style and structure and includes citations. It communicates the main project outcomes. Any work exceeding the specified word limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion, i.e. the maximum mark one could take for Presentation is 10 out of 20 marks.

For a **distinction**, a student would have to attempt a challenging project (this should be discussed with the potential supervisor) and gain a high mark under each of the above headings. To award a distinction the markers assess the project according to the following criteria.

Project Proposal:

- *Background research* (35%)*:* the student shows a clear understanding of the researched material. Potential approaches from the literature are reviewed and critically evaluated, highlighting strengths and weaknesses of each.
- *Presentation of the problem* (15%)*:* a problem is specified and clearly outlined. This includes the aims and objectives of the project, its context and the technical/user requirements.
- *Plan for developing the solution* (30%): an appropriate development/research methodology/theory and methods are chosen, and their suitability is well-justified. The project is broken down into subtasks that are logically coherent and a realistic timeplan is produced. In the case of open research questions "fallback" plans should be laid out; e.g. you can provide a risk analysis plan and risk mitigation strategies.
- *Presentation of the proposal* (20%): complex issues are explained clearly and concisely. The content is well-organised and structured in a way that demonstrates the links between the concepts presented. The proposal demonstrates in-depth understanding of researched material. The report cites diverse resources using a consistent referencing style. The proposal is of professional quality. Any work exceeding the specified word limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion, i.e. the maximum mark one could take for Presentation is 10 out of 20 marks.

Project Report:

- *Specification and design* (20%): the specification of the planned project, the design of the system/software/research/data analysis framework, AI or machine learning pipeline clearly demonstrate how to meet the aims and objectives of the project and the requirements. The report explains how all components fit together in a coherent way, underpinned by relevant literature.
- *Implementation, or execution of research* (30%): The key stages of the implementation or research are clearly explained and justified based on relevant literature and/or research conducted in the context of the project. The implementation or investigation is appropriate to the project objectives and requirements and is carried out to a high standard as demonstrated in the report.
- *Testing and evaluation, results, analysis, and reflection* (30%): The report uses appropriate testing and evaluation methods and justifies their adoption based on relevant literature and/or research conducted in the context of the project. It describes systematic testing and evaluation activities, and a solution (e.g. system, software/model, or a data analysis/AI/machine learning approach) that

demonstrates deep insight into the problem/research question/aims and objectives. The report attempts to provide a critical and justified reflection upon the project's contribution and its limitations. Key results are accurately and critically analysed. Relevant conclusions are drawn.

- *Presentation of the proposal/report and documentation* (20%): The report is self-contained, providing background and context. It is well-organised and demonstrates the concepts presented. Relevant literature is exploited and cited to support the analysis and the discussions, and in general the report analyses and explains complex issues clearly. The overall approach and solution are well-justified. The report cites relevant resources using consistent style and is of professional quality. Any work exceeding the specified word limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion, i.e. the maximum mark one could take for Presentation is 10 out of 20 marks.

Work that meets some, but not all, of the criteria for distinction, or partially meets some of them, may be considered for a **merit**.

If the project produces a piece of software or code, the student is required to give the supervisor a demonstration of the software in action. You are also encouraged to provide a video presentation/demo of your software/code/implementation accessible to independent markers and external examiners, as described in Section 5, Writing and Submitting the PG Project.

The proposal and the report go through the Turnitin detection service and receive a "plagiarism score" and an "AI writing detection score". The proposal and the report are marked by independent markers and moderated by the supervisor. Their comments are made available via Moodle's Turnitin Feedback Studio. In the event of disagreement between the supervisor and the marker (marks differ more than 5%) a third marker will also assess the project. External Examiners are given access to review all projects, although in practice each External reviews only a sample. However, they routinely review marginal cases or projects with strong disagreement between markers (e.g. three markers disagree, or marks are in different grade categories).

4. Carrying out the Project

In your project proposal, you will set out an outline timetable for the project plan. This provides a yardstick against which you and your supervisor will monitor your progress. How you arrange your time from day to day is largely up to you.

Students are responsible for maintaining contact with their supervisors during the project. It is best to agree *in advance* how often meetings will be held and what other forms the interaction will take. Even students who feel able to carry out their work without frequent meetings must keep their supervisor in touch with what they are doing. A student should not remain silent for months and then appear in September with a completed report. If the

Exam Board feels that the student's conduct has prevented adequate supervision, it may insist on a searching oral examination or it may refuse to accept the project for examination at all. This is because according to the Regulations, students cannot submit a PG project without receiving supervision.

Students are entitled to regular email correspondence, ongoing meetings, and timely responses from their supervisor. Feedback on drafts of the project report may be provided at the supervisor's discretion, provided that draft materials are submitted in reasonable time. Normally at least three meetings, either in-person or online, with the supervisor prior to submission of the project report are expected:

- initial discussion about the topic, aims and objectives and/or research questions, methodology and methods, identifying any research ethics approval that will need to be obtained and sketching out an initial action plan;
- an intermediate meeting to assess progress and discuss the likely structure of the project report;
- final meeting for troubleshooting and demonstration of the solution.

Bear in mind that your supervisor will have periods of leave or commitments away from College and you must plan accordingly. If supervision does not meet the agreed criteria, the Programme Director and the PG project module convenor should be contacted.

If you undertake your project on a machine other than one maintained by the School, it is your responsibility to back up your work; software/hardware problems with non-School machines (including last-minute problems with printers, scanners, or storage devices) cannot be used as excuses for missing the submission deadline for the project.

The supervisor's role is to provide support and encouragement, to direct the student's attention to relevant literature, advise on technical aspects, and give guidance on the standard and amount of work required.

This last point can be a source of difficulty between student and supervisor. Students naturally look to the supervisor for reassurance that their project merits a PG award. You must bear in mind that the supervisor can only give you his/her opinion. Whether a PG project submission is of PG standard is a matter for the Examination Board to decide. It can happen, and occasionally does happen, that the supervisor thinks that a project deserves to pass but the other examiners disagree.

Make sure you allow enough time for the writing up of the report. Supervisors are encouraged to read and comment on the draft report; however, officially supervisors are under no obligation to read full drafts of a student's work, or even the final version of the work; this responsibility is left to their discretion. Some supervisors strongly recommend that you start drafting the report as you conduct the project, rather than leaving the write-up until the end. The total time allocated to the report should be about a month for a full-timer, two or three months for a part-timer. There must be time for the supervisor to read and comment on it and for the student to make changes (perhaps extensive changes) on the basis of the comments. Bear in mind that your supervisor is supervising several students (typically more than 10 new project students each year, plus students for previous years who

have deferred project submission) and cannot be expected to give you full and prompt attention if you all produce your draft reports at the same time, especially a few days before the deadline.

5. Writing and Submitting the PG Project Proposal & Report

The maximum length for proposals is set at 3,000 words, with an allowance of up to 20 percent above this limit. The maximum length for the report is 10,000 words, also with a permissible extension of 20 percent. Word counts do not include References or Appendices. Any work exceeding the specified limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion (see below). For details regarding the marking criteria and the allocation of marks to each component, please consult the Proposal and Report Marking Criteria documents available on Moodle.

A project proposal should explain the motivation and context for the chosen topic, and provide a well-defined problem statement or research question. The aim and objectives must specify what the project seeks to achieve and set boundaries for its work. The proposal should briefly identify related work in the field, showing awareness of key developments and gaps. It should describe the methodology and justify proposed methods and technologies, describe expected outcomes or deliverables, and suggest suitable criteria/metrics for evaluation of the proposed work. A realistic timeline with project stages is important, along with consideration of potential challenges and risks. Finally, the proposal should include relevant references.

The main purpose of the report is to explain what you did in your project. Markers and readers should be able to see clearly what you set out to do and what you achieved. It should be primarily a descriptive and evaluative assessment of the final project as implemented, rather than a chronological account of how the project developed. It should describe the problems to which you addressed yourself and explain why you tackled them in the way you did. It should include your own assessment of how successful the project was. A project which falls short of its goals - perhaps a system is not fully implemented or perhaps the results are disappointing in some way – can still be acceptable as a PG project and, depending on the project, can even be awarded a merit or distinction mark; you can demonstrate your grasp of the topic in the discussions and the observations you make about the project's shortcomings.

You should assume that the markers/readers of your report will be academics from the SCMS. They will therefore have good knowledge of general issues in the area of your work but may not be familiar with detailed issues relating to narrow topics in the subject. As a result, you may need to include some brief motivational and technical material for such topics. If the project consisted of developing an application in a specialised area - such as bioinformatics, environmental sciences, geography, physics, medicine - it might be necessary to include some explanatory background. Remember that the project is intended to show your abilities in the PG programme of study.

We provide a **Proposal/Report Template on Moodle**, but we do not insist on a rigid structure for project proposals/reports; projects vary considerably, and the proposals/reports naturally reflect this variation. Nevertheless, reports typically include five

to seven chapters, references and appendices. Some suggested chapters are given below, although some reports may not include all of them while others may include additional ones. Your supervisor should be able to advise you on a suitable structure for your project. The following are chapters that are typically present in project reports:

- **Introduction**: provide the context and motivation for the project, as well as the problem statement or specification. Describe the aims and objectives of the project and introduce the structure of report (what you will cover in each chapter). Your project proposal should include a preliminary version of this chapter.
- **Background/Literature Review**: what the reader needs to know to understand the rest of the report. Although the background/review can build on the material included in the proposal, in the report you can present a more extensive coverage of the relevant areas and offer a critical analysis.
- **Methodology and Methods**: describe the overall project methodology and the methods that will be used to meet the objectives of the project/the specifications. This can build on the material included in the project proposal. A separate chapter on methodology and methods may not be relevant for some projects, in such case information/material about methodology and methods is included in other chapters of the report.
- **Analysis and Design**: present requirements analysis and design of a system, software, or data processing/AI/machine-learning pipeline, explaining how your analysis and design meet the aims and objectives of the project. Comparison of different choices for methods, algorithms and data structures will add value to your report. Overall system structure. Dataflow, entity- relationship, and object diagrams as appropriate help readers appreciate your work more and demonstrate deep understanding.
- **Implementation**: focus on important points that you want the examiners to pay attention to rather than attempting a detailed description of the whole program/system. (Program documentation is not a substitute for a project report. Documentation is meant to be consulted as and when necessary; a report is meant to be read.)
- **Testing and Evaluation**: a description of the test and/or evaluation plan, i.e. how the program/system/model was verified (e.g. software testing, experiments), how the overall solution was evaluated (e.g., depending on the project, this may involve user study, questionnaires, use cases, test cases, simulations). Put the actual test results in an appendix. This section may also include a user evaluation, where appropriate.
- **Results**: this chapter is relevant to projects where experiments or simulations were carried out with the code written. Why were certain experiments carried out but not others? What were the important parameters in the simulation and how did they affect the results? If there are many graphs and tables associated with this chapter they may be put in an appendix, but it is generally better to keep these close to the text they illustrate, as this is easier for the reader.
- **Discussion**: critical evaluation of the results and reflection on the approach and the project, including strong and weak points, lessons learnt, design decisions which, looking back, would be made differently, ways in which the project could be improved or extended. The project does not need to have a positive conclusion. For example, it might have proved that some system, model or algorithm was not effective or successful. You should indicate to what extent your objectives have been achieved.
- **Conclusions**: summary of the project. Provide areas of possible future work.

Project reports also include:

- **References** – this is not a chapter of the report and should not be numbered. It includes all sources cited in the body of the report (in-text citations). A typical reference in the report might take the form, "Donar and Kebab (1996) suggest that high cholesterol levels do not lead to heart disease...." or "empirical eating studies show that.... (Donar and Kebab, 1996)". The full title of the article or book or web page in which Donar and Kebab make these assertions is then given in the list of references. Where possible, use an article or a book rather than a web page. The idea of references is not just to substantiate statements and arguments but also to make it possible for other people to find the references. Normally, for a book, you should list author(s), title, publisher, date of publication, relevant page number(s). It can be difficult to locate the relevant part of a book if the page numbers are omitted. For an article list author(s), title of article, name of journal, volume and issue number, date, and page numbers of the article. For a web page give the URL and the date on which the page was consulted. In the academic world references are regarded as very important and poor referencing will certainly detract from the project report. Detailed instructions are included in the following subsections.

  Do not under any circumstances quote from a source without making it clear that you are quoting. Any quote must be accompanied by an appropriate reference.

  Bibliography - a bibliography sometimes also lists sources that you consulted for background research but did not cite in your text. This may be useful for certain types of projects, such as Information systems projects, HCI projects and others. Have a look at the following links to about the differences between References and Bibliography:

  https://www.scribbr.co.uk/referencing/harvard-bibliography/

  https://www.eapfoundation.com/writing/references/section/

- **Appendices – You must include at least one appendix with link to your code on GitHub.** Appendices also might include a questionnaire used to gather information, a list of the people interviewed and their companies, transcripts of interviews, detailed data, program listings, test results, etc. You may include appendices with detailed results of experiments, user or system manuals etc. For a system manual, include all the technical details (where is the code? what do you type to compile it? etc.) that would enable a student to continue your project next year, to be able to amend your code and extend it. For a user manual: give enough information for someone to use what you have designed and implemented. Test results. Code listing: Your code should be well commented. Any appendix should be referred to in the main part of the report and not just stuck at the end of the report without explanation. It is very important that an examiner can find evidence for the claims you make in your report. The appendices are the place to put such evidence without cluttering up the main part of the report. Sample projects, completed by previous students are available in the library.

There is no stipulated minimum length for the project report. In practice, the length of the text, not including references, program listings and related technical submissions in appendices, is generally about 10,000 words to cover all the above-mentioned aspects. A shorter report would be acceptable if the content was good. Length is not a virtue; the maximum length for a report is 12,000 words. Word counts do not include References or Appendices. Any work exceeding the specified limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion, i.e. the maximum mark one could take for Presentation is 10 out

of 20 marks. Resist the temptation to include general background material - the sort of material you would expect to find in lecture notes or textbooks. The examiners want to know about your project. They have many reports to read in a short period and are not pleased to have their time wasted by waffle.

The work that is presented for the markers/examiners' consideration should be your own, expressed in your own words. The Turnitin detection service now provides an "AI writing detection score" and **the College's Assessment Offences Regulation has now penalties for inappropriate use of AI tools.** If you take a program or part of a program from somewhere and incorporate it in your project, you must make it clear in your report that you are not claiming that this is your own work. If your project was developed in the context of some large system or as an extension to previously existing work, it is essential that the reader should be able to see where the other work ends and your work begins. Plagiarism is discussed more fully below.

Students are advised to pay attention to the quality of their English. All too often, a project containing good work is marred by a report which is turgid, obscure, or simply ungrammatical. This criticism does not apply solely, or even primarily, to foreign students. While the project is meant to provide evidence of a student's ability in the area of the PG Programme of study rather than in English, an examiner cannot be expected to look kindly on a report that is badly written.

Formatting instructions for project proposal and report

You should lay the components of your document out in this order:

Title Page
Academic declaration
Abstract (not needed for proposal)
Table of Contents (not needed for proposal)
List of Figures and Tables (not needed for proposal)
Acknowledgements (not needed for proposal)
Main Text organised in chapters, sections, subsections
References
Appendices

Always use third person writing – the only exception is the Academic declaration section which should be in the first person. Type should be 11pt for all text, 22pt for chapter titles and 18pt for section and 16pt for subsection titles. In the title page you should use 28pt for the title of the project, 11pt for the author's name and 11pt for affiliations. A smaller size than 11pt may be used for footnotes. Any readable font of the size specified can be used but you should be consistent. Margins should be of 25mm (bound and top edges) and a minimum of 20mm (other edges). Your text should be both left and right adjusted. No first line indents should be used and there should be a single blank line between paragraphs. The page size for all documents is A4. Pages should be numbered from the beginning of the main text and should be centred at the bottom of the page. Page numbers lie outside the page boundaries (as a part of the bottom margin). The title of the document should appear as a

running header on each page (centred). This header lies outside the page boundaries (as a part of the top margin). There should be no other running headers or footers (note that footers are not the same as footnotes). The title page and cover page should not be numbered.

Title Page

The Title Page must show the title of the Project, identify the author by name, declare the purpose of the document and the word count, and give the date as shown below in this example:

Title of Project Here

A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the

MSc in Title_of_PG_Programme

by First_Name Last_Name

School of Computing and Mathematical Sciences

Birkbeck, University of London

September 20XX

Word count

Sections and Subsections

Within the body of the report, titles of sections and subsections should be in bold type, in 18pt and 16pt respectively, and numbered with level numbers (for example, 4.4.2) to a depth of 3 at most. The first digit in the level number should be the same as the number of the chapter that contains it. Level numbers in the appendices should have the appendix identification (which should be a capital letter) in the first position of the level number (for example, A.2.3 for section 2.3 in appendix A). First level headings (sections) can be capitalised or not capitalised, depending on which style you prefer but you should be consistent. They should be preceded by the equivalent of two blank lines and followed by a single blank line with subsequent text beginning on a new line. Second level headings (subsections) should be in lower case but with the first letter of all the main words capitalised. They should be preceded by a single blank line and followed by a single blank line with subsequent text beginning on a new line.

Figures and Tables

All figures should be numbered with consecutive Arabic numerals after the word ‘Figure’. The numbering should start afresh in each chapter, but the numeral should be prefixed with

the chapter number (for example, Figure 3.2 for the second figure in chapter 3). All figures should have descriptive captions following the numeral and should be mentioned in the text. When referred to in the text, the word 'figure' should be spelt in full. Similar conventions should be used for tables, using the word 'Table', and using independent numbering from figures.

Alternatively, you can use the MS Word **Proposal/Report Template** that is available on Moodle. The Word template is a generic format for proposals and reports. The template is only a guide for the font size, page margins, headings style etc that should be used, and it should not be relied upon to determine the structure of your project proposal or report.

The template makes use of custom-defined styles to provide a consistent look and feel, as well as binding of certain document text (e.g. title and author), with the underlying document metadata/info, to ensure consistency between the metadata/info and the document text. Also, dates in the document (e.g. on the front page and in the declaration) are automatically updated to match the last saved timestamp of the file.

Software and programs

Program listings and output (other than brief extracts necessary to the discussion) should not appear in the main text but should be placed as appendices at the end of the report. You should take some care over the layout of listings; begin each new function (class or whatever) on a new page and provide an index to the functions with page references at the beginning of the program. At the very least, you must ensure that the program listings are legible. **Any code reused from other sources should be clearly identified and referenced in the text and in the Appendix to avoid plagiarism.** This also applies to open-source code. If you are unsure on which parts of your code need appropriate referencing do consult your project supervisor.

The production of computer software which can be executed and tested is an essential part of the project and should be submitted with the report, following the instructions on Moodle. Typically, your report should include an Appendix (similar to a README file) with description of the files provided and an Appendix with instructions on software execution.

It is required that all source code and any associated files used in the project are submitted using a **GitHub repository.** It is *your* responsibility to ensure that files transferred from your own machines to your GitHub repository are in the correct format and complete, accessible by your supervisor and the marker, and that any programs execute as intended on the School's systems, if needed, prior to the submission date. As mentioned above, i**nstructions on software use should also be included in an Appendix of the report, entitled "Instructions for using the software".**

You can either create your own GitHub.com repository to host your project code or submit using a GitHub repository allocated under the Birkbeck Campus organisation- see instructions in the "Submission of source code and files" subsection below.

Include a detailed README file in your repository. This document should provide clear instructions on running your code, including setup steps, dependencies, and usage guidelines. Use descriptive and meaningful commit messages for each change you make to the codebase. Clear commit messages make it easier to track changes and understand the purpose of each commit.

You can find instructions on how to create a git release here: https://docs.github.com/en/repositories/releasing-projects-on-github/managing-releases-in-a-repository

Submission of the PG proposal and report

The report must be submitted electronically to the Moodle Virtual Learning Environment (VLE). There is a penalty for late submission, as described on Moodle.

You must upload an electronic copy of your proposal and report on the Moodle Virtual Learning Environment (VLE) (https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/ - username and password are required) for your project to be marked. In the **file name field provide the title of your project.** The submission can be in one of the following formats: MS-Word, PDF, or RTF. The proposal/report is submitted to the Turnitin Detection Service, which will compare your work with millions of documents on the web, including projects produced by other students, highlighting any passages that appear to come from an existing source. Turnitin automatically checks submissions for any use of AI tools. (As a side-effect of this process, your project will be added to Turnitin secure database.) The results of this process will be passed on to the examiners.

Submitting your work online via Moodle (or via any other electronic medium) implies that you acknowledge that you have read and understood the sections of plagiarism in the College Policy on assessment offences and confirm that the work is your own, with the work of others clearly acknowledged. You also give your permission to submit your file to the plagiarism testing database that the College is using and test it using plagiarism detection software (Turnitin), search engines or meta-searching software.

Moodle will accept electronic submissions by the cut-off deadline, but a penalty applies. Please consult College's late submission policy for penalties (also available on Moodle).

Students should leave themselves plenty of time to meet the deadline. Deadlines are listed on Moodle. In the event of serious medical or other problems, a mitigating circumstances claim should be submitted to the Programme Administrator at cs-pg@bbk.ac.uk. You are not required to seek permission from the module convenor or your supervisor before submitting a mitigating circumstances claim; however, both would appreciate being notified by email of your intention to do so.

If you undertake your project on a machine other than one maintained by the School, it is your responsibility to back up your work; software/hardware problems with non- School

machines (including last-minute problems with printers, scanners or storage devices) cannot be used as excuses for missing the submission deadline for the project.

Simply failing to submit your project proposal or report without permission to defer will be considered to be the same as failing the PG project, in the sense that it will count as one of the two attempts that you are permitted to make at passing that element of assessment**.** Please note that the module convenor and the supervisors cannot give you this permission. They do not approve extensions, deferrals, late submissions, or mitigating circumstance claims. They are not involved in the approval process in any way and cannot make claims on your behalf. However, both the module convenor and the supervisor would appreciate being notified by email of your intention to do so.

You can submit a claim through your own MyBirkbeck account. For advice on these matters, please contact the PG admin team and/or your Programme Director.

Submission of source code and files

All source code and any associated files used in the project must be submitted using a GitHub repository. Include in your project proposal and in your final report the link to your repository.

GitHub is integrated in many modern IDEs including IntelliJ, Android Studio and VS Code, and you can submit your project source code directly. It is possible and encouraged to use your allocated GitHub repository throughout your project. The last repository update before your project report submission deadline (considering special circumstances and late submissions) will be the version of your work that will be marked.

If you are not familiar with GitHub, there are video tutorials that demonstrate how to submit your files using a web browser.

1. **Git and GitHub for Beginners - Crash Course** (1h 8m) by freeCodeCamp on YouTube. This comprehensive course covers Git fundamentals, GitHub setup, key commands, branching, and workflows. Great for beginners getting started with version control. Link: Git and GitHub for Beginners - Crash Course

2. **GitHub for Beginners - YouTube Playlist.** A playlist designed to help master GitHub basics step-by-step, ideal for new coders or those improving version control skills. Link: GitHub for Beginners Playlist

3. **Git & GitHub Crash Course 2025** by Traversy Media (Just under 50 minutes). A clear and concise crash course covering core Git commands, setup, repository management, branching, and pull requests. Link: Git & GitHub Crash Course 2025

4. **GitHub Basics Made Easy: A Fast Beginner's Tutorial!** by Skill Foundry (23m) A beginner-friendly tutorial explaining Git basics, GitHub setup, and key workflows with GitHub Desktop. Link: GitHub Basics Made Easy

These resources are well-regarded for clarity, depth, and accessibility for beginners.

For help using GitHub please also look at the GitHub Guides.

You can either create your own GitHub.com repository to host your project code or submit using a GitHub repository allocated under the Birkbeck Campus organisation.

If you want to use the Birkbeck GitHub repository:

1. Log on to Moodle and access the relevant MSc project module.
2. In the "REPORT SUBMISSION" tile or section, you will find a link marked " MSc project code and files submission to GitHub"
3. Click on the link. This will take you to a GitHub Sign In page entitled "Sign In to GitHub to continue to GitHub Classroom". (If you are already signed in to GitHub, then you will be directed to the MSc Project 2025-26 classroom)
4. Sign In to GitHub and authorise the GitHub Classroom. You can use either an existing GitHub account or create a new (free) account.
5. On successful Sign In, you will be taken to GitHub Classroom where you will be asked to select your name from a list and confirm your selection; if you cannot find your name create a new repository.
6. You have completed the process and the URL of your allocated repository will be displayed. You will also receive an email confirming your repository details.

A video tutorial of the process above is available. If you are not familiar with GitHub, the video tutorial above also demonstrates the simplest way to submit your files using a web browser. If you experience problems claiming your Birkbeck GitHub repository, please email the Systems Group (sg@dcs.bbk.ac.uk).

Whichever option you choose, please remember to include instructions for using your software/code in an Appendix titled "Instructions for using the software." This should also contain a link to your repository. Without this link, markers may not be able to access your repository, which could lead to a lower mark.

Late submission of projects

Extensions are not allowed. The absolute cut off deadline for late submission of proposal or report is 10 working days after the normal submission.

It is School policy to accept and mark late items of assessment submitted before the cut off deadline. Students do not need to negotiate new deadlines and there is no need to obtain prior consent of the module convenor or project supervisor to submit late. The School is unable to accept submissions after the cut off deadline.

Any type of assessment submitted late is given two marks: a penalty mark and the "normal mark" that would have been awarded if the work had not been late. If the work is not of a pass standard a single mark is given. For modules where coursework is compulsory to pass the module, but it is not marked (like the project kernel), coursework received before the

absolute cut off deadline is not penalised. Marks shown on Moodle are the "normal mark", i.e. no penalty is applied on marks shown on Moodle. Penalty marks are applied at a later stage by the administrator, after considering any extenuating circumstances.

If a student believes that they have good cause to be excused the penalty for late submission, they must make a mitigating circumstances claim for consideration by the Mitigation Sub-Committee. The claim form and accompanying documentary evidence must be submitted within 7 days of the cut off deadline. If no such documentation is received prior to the meeting of the Mitigation Sub-Committee the "normal mark" will not be considered and the penalty mark will stand.

All requests are held over and considered by a sub-group of the Postgraduate Exam Board prior to a meeting of the full Exam Board. This sub-group, called the Mitigation SubCommittee, will meet termly and/or prior to the full Exam Board, as appropriate, and its results are presented to the full Exam Board.

Project deferral

Students can apply to defer the examination of their project until the following September (i.e., at the end of an extra year of study). Students for whom the project is the only part of the PG programme that remains to be completed may enrol as project-only students for one further year, at one third of the regular fee.

However, getting a deferral does not mean that the student must wait one full year to submit the report the following September. Students who deferred the project can submit their report earlier, if they have completed the work. Although PG projects are examined only at the November meeting of the Postgraduate Exam Board, the School will try to mark submissions of deferred projects and approve the student results at an earlier Examination Board, if circumstances allow it. For example, if you can submit by January then your report could be marked together with the submission of the January PG cohort, and the result may be approved at an earlier Exam Board meeting. The administrator will advise you on the deadlines that you must follow.

Students who wish to defer the PG project must apply under the mitigating circumstances procedure. Although Registry's published deadline for deferral of September assessments is 1 August, in practice later requests for deferral can be considered. **The mitigating circumstances form should be sent to the Programme Administrator by 1st September.**

6. Academic Integrity and Assessment Offences

The College has a duty to maintain academic standards by ensuring the fairness and integrity of all aspects of its assessment processes. Candidates are expected to complete their assessments with integrity. The College will treat any instance of an alleged assessment offence very seriously and take appropriate action against any student who is alleged to have contravened its Policy and Procedures on academic integrity. An assessment offence is defined as "an action which could give a candidate an unfair advantage in any element of

assessment over other candidates participating in the same assessment". The following are examples of assessment offences:

- ***Plagiarism*** - the presentation of another person's thoughts or words or artefacts or other output in such a way that they could be assumed to be your own.

- ***Collusion*** - producing a piece of work for formal assessment with the assistance of another person, or persons, when the assignment was to have been undertaken and completed by you working individually.

- ***Contract Cheating*** - where a student submits work for assessment in part or in entirety where they have used one or more of a range of services provided by a third party, such as an essay mill, which is not permitted. Please be aware that services like Chegg are willing to cooperate with the School on contact cheating - they have provided us details of the question submitters and full answers published.

- ***Use of text generated from AI tools, such as ChatGPT, Gemini and others***– any use of content generated or identified through AI should be appropriately acknowledged within the main text by means of in-text citation, with the prompts employed provided in an Appendix. The use of prompts that are intended to circumvent AI-detection- e.g. requesting the paraphrasing of material to evade such detection or to simulate authorship by a less experienced student- may be taken as academic misconduct, as they indicate a deliberate awareness of dishonest practice. Furthermore, replicating AI-generated text, particularly in a verbatim manner, reflects inadequate poor engagement with and assimilation of the material/concepts, which may consequently lead to lower marks. Please note that Turnitin scans and assesses all submissions for evidence of AI tool usage.

For the purposes of module assessments (including proposals and reports), the use of AI or AI-assisted technologies in the execution of substantive project tasks- such as the generation of scientific insights, the identification of research gaps, systems and interaction design, methodology and methods design, data analysis and interpretation, or the formulation of scientific hypotheses, project objectives or conclusions- is prohibited. These are core learning tasks that must be completed by the student. Using AI in these areas, especially if it involves relying on false or invented references in the literature review or in supporting research, methodology, methods or design decisions, is strictly not allowed. Such technologies may be employed exclusively for the refinement of language, readability, and presentation of written manuscripts.

Each piece of submitted work MUST have an "Academic Declaration" to certify that the student has read and understood the sections of plagiarism in the College Regulation and confirm that the work is their own, with the work of others fully acknowledged. Submissions must be also accompanied by a declaration giving us permission to submit coursework to a plagiarism testing database that the College is subscribed to.

By submitting your proposal and report, you confirm that:

1. You have not impersonated or allowed yourself to be impersonated by any person for the purposes of this assessment.
2. This assessment is your original work and no part of it has been copied from any other source, except where due acknowledgement is made.
3. You have not previously submitted this work for any other module/programme.
4. You give permission for your assessment response to be reproduced, communicated, compared and archived for plagiarism detection, benchmarking or educational purposes.
5. You understand that plagiarism is the presentation of the work, idea or creation of another person or organisation, as though it is your own. It is a form of cheating and is a form of academic misconduct that may lead to disciplinary action.
6. You understand that this assessment is undertaken without invigilation and that you have not communicated with and will not communicate with anyone concerning this assessment before the deadline for submission, unless it is expressly permitted by the assessment instructions.
7. No part of this assessment has been produced for, or communicated to you by any other person, unless it is expressly permitted by the assessment instructions.
8. You understand that you are studying towards a University of London qualification and that this award may ultimately be revoked (this means you will lose it), if in the future, an investigation uncovers deliberate academic misconduct.

What is Plagiarism?

Plagiarism is defined as "copying a whole or substantial parts of a paper from a source text (e.g. a web site, journal article, book or encyclopaedia), without proper acknowledgement; paraphrasing of another's piece of work closely, with minor changes but with the essential meaning, form and/or progression of ideas maintained; piecing together sections of the work of others into a new whole; procuring a paper from a company or essay bank (including Internet sites); submitting another student's work, with or without that student's knowledge; submitting a paper written by someone else (e.g. a peer or relative), and passing it off as one's own; representing a piece of joint or group work as one's own".

There are many ways of plagiarising the work of others. Some examples are given below.

- Copying chunks of text without using quotation marks and without appropriate acknowledgement; for example, cutting-and-pasting text from websites, blogs or online research papers, or copying papers written by students who did a similar project.
- Copying text and making very minor changes, and without appropriate acknowledgement. This is an example of unacceptable paraphrasing.
- Copying a picture or photo from the Internet, without appropriate acknowledgement. If you use images protected by copyright, you must also obtain permission from the copyright owner. See College Library for guidance.
- Using another person's numerical spreadsheet, software, or results, without appropriate acknowledgement.

- Duplicating your own work, for example by submitting almost the same work for two different assignments, e.g., a piece of coursework and the PG project.
- Using code developed by another person without acknowledging the original author as the person who developed it.

The College considers plagiarism a serious offence, and as such it warrants disciplinary action. This is particularly important in assessed pieces of work where plagiarism goes so far as to dishonestly claim credit for ideas that have been taken by someone else.

Understanding plagiarism

To help students understand plagiarism, the College offers the learning module "Avoiding Plagiarism" on Moodle. Students need to self-enrol.

Typically, each piece of submitted coursework must have an "Academic Declaration" signed by the student(s), which certifies that the authors have read and understood the plagiarism guidelines and confirm that the work is their own, with the work of others fully acknowledged. Submissions must be also accompanied by a declaration giving us permission to submit coursework to a plagiarism-testing database that the College is subscribed.

The Academic Declaration text should include the following statements: *"This report is the result of my own work except where explicitly indicated in the text. I give my permission for it to be submitted to the TURNITIN Plagiarism Detection Service. I have read and understood the sections on plagiarism in the College website and the Policy and Procedures on academic integrity.*

The report may be freely copied and distributed provided the source is explicitly acknowledged."

If you submit work without acknowledgement or reference of other students (or other people or use of AI tools) then this is one of the most serious forms of plagiarism. When you wish to include material that is not the result of your own efforts alone, you should make a reference to their contribution, just as if that were a published piece of work. You should put a clear acknowledgement (either in the text itself, or as a footnote) identifying the students that you have worked with, and the contribution that they have made to your submission.

Avoiding plagiarism

The College offers the learning module "Avoiding Plagiarism" on Moodle to all students. This module will help you understand plagiarism and explain in detail how one can avoid plagiarism. Instructions on how to enrol on this module are provided on Moodle. Below some examples are given from this module.

Citing Other Peoples' Work or AI tools Properly

Citations give brief details of the source at the point in the text where the source is used.

Citations using the Harvard system show the author and date of publication and the page number for quotations. For example:

Oakshott (2001) argues that ...

Or

Oakshott (2001, p. 3) argues that "democracy is dead".

Or

According to Gemini (2025, prompt in Appendix C), “the most popular approach to…”

If a quotation is longer than two or three lines, it is often indented using block formatting. By convention, block quotations do not usually need quotation marks - check with your course lecturer for guidance.

For example:

Worsley (2002) argues that Karl Marx is still very influential:
Karl Marx has probably affected the course of twentieth-century history more than any other single thinker. Because of this, his ideas have generated a vast output of writings (Worsley, 2002, p. 1).

Reference:
Worsley, P., 2002. Marx and Marxism. 2nd ed. London: Routledge.

Referencing

References include the full bibliographic information about the source, such as the author(s)'s name(s), date of publication, title of work, place of publication, and publisher. This information is usually given in the section called *References* at the end of the report. The key principle is that you should give enough information to allow another person to find the source for themselves.

Here are some examples using the Harvard referencing system:

[when you are referring to a book]

Lewin, K., 1951. Field Theory in Social Science. New York: Harper and Row.

[when you are referring to a chapter in a book, where 'ed.' means editor, and 'edn.' means 'edition']

Piaget, J., 1970. Piaget's theory. In: P. Smith, ed., Handbook of child psychology. 3rd edn. New York: Wiley, 1970, pp. 34-76.

[when you are referring to a journal article]

Holmqvist, M., 2003. A Dynamic Model of Intra- and Interorganizational Learning. Organization Studies, 24(1), 95-123.

[when you are referring to a webpage]

W3C, Web Accessibility Guidelines and Techniques, available online at

https://www.w3.org/WAI/standards-guidelines/. Last accessed 12/02/2015.

Independent of their type (e.g., book, article, webpage), all references are included at the end of a document in alphabetical order, following the Harvard style, starting from the author's name as in the example above.

If your references include sources identified with the use of AI tools, then it is good practice to review the results carefully as these tools can generate inaccurate or misleading information and even "hallucinate" nonexistent sources or facts. A good starting point is to verify that there are no fabricated data, e.g. verify authors and title, research purpose of article is stated correctly, study design or experiments described correctly, terminology is used properly, theoretical, conceptual and/or methodological issues are framed appropriately and they are not misrepresented, significant issues are not omitted.

Paraphrasing

Here are some examples from the plagiarism module that might help you to understand which forms of paraphrasing are acceptable and which are treated as plagiarism.

First, the original extract is given, taken from the book, Marx, and Marxism, by Peter Worsley.

Karl Marx has probably affected the course of twentieth-century history more than any other single thinker. Because of this, his ideas have generated a vast output of writings, ranging from texts written by revolutionaries aimed at telling people how to do revolution - how to carry on Marx's work of demolishing capitalism and creating a new socialist society - to the many hundreds of volumes dedicated to proving that Marx was wrong about practically everything.

Acceptable practice: Worsley (2002) suggests that Karl Marx has had a significant impact on the course of twentieth-century history. He argues that Marx's ideas have led to a great deal of writing, across a spectrum from promoting his call for revolution to trying to show he was wrong in his analysis and predictions.

Plagiarism: Karl Marx, the inspiration for revolutionary activity in many countries, has probably affected the course of 20C history more than almost any other thinker. Because of this, his ideas have generated a vast output of writings, ranging from books written about revolution - how to demolish capitalism and create a new socialist society - to books dedicated to proving that Marx was wrong about practically everything.

Copying the whole text without using quotation marks and without appropriate acknowledgement is considered plagiarism: Karl Marx has probably affected the course of

twentieth-century history more than any other single thinker. Because of this, his ideas have generated a vast output of writings, ranging from texts written by revolutionaries aimed at telling people how to do revolution - how to carry on Marx's work of demolishing capitalism and creating a new socialist society - to the many hundreds of volumes dedicated to proving that Marx was wrong about practically everything.

7. Useful Resources

Here are some resources that can help you to better manage your project and avoid plagiarism.

- Avoiding Plagiarism: https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/enrol/index.php?id=45
- Referencing Systems: Harvard guide to citing references is available online at: https://www5.open.ac.uk/library/referencing-and-plagiarism/quick-guide-to-harvard-referencing-cite-them-right
- Study Skills: https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=7881

If you need guidance relating to your studies and identifying needs for additional support, please contact your personal tutor. The personal tutor may be also able to help if you have other problems that may be relevant to your Programme of study.

The College also provide advice sessions on study skills, such as planning the workload, writing, reading and exam preparation; free workshops on critical writing, essay writing, examination essays, examination revision, learning strategies and memory techniques; help with the English language, help with coursework and other written assessment, subject specific preparation and study skills. Further details are online at: http://www.bbk.ac.uk/student-services/learning-development .